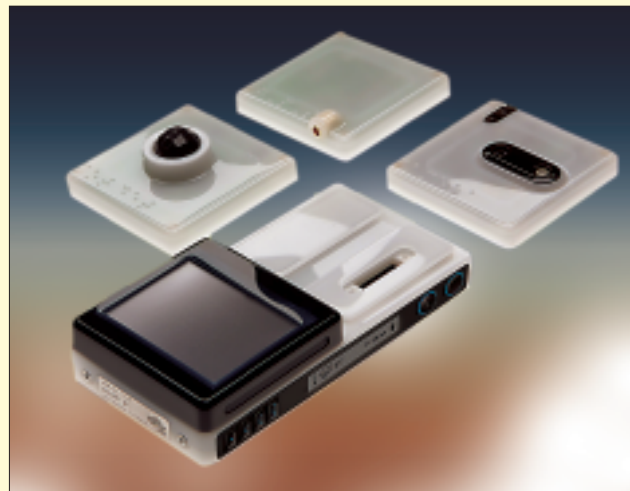


Bug Labs Platform

Didn't you love playing with Lego blocks as a kid? The freedom to build what you fancied, with creative new designs for buildings and cars that were uniquely designed by yourself. Ahh... those were the days. Today, you have to make do with gadgets that millions of other also own. You can either become an iPerson, like the rest of the world, or you can be bitten by the creativity bug.

The Bug Labs Platform, which is open source incidentally, allows you to build yourself a gadget, like you did when playing with Lego. You can develop your own modules, or just be lazy and buy the ones you want, and then attach it all to the microprocessor base, and have your very own gadget. You can even write your own programs, or be lazy again, and download those written by the community, which are easily available (don't you love Open Source?), to get the functionality you want, nothing more, nothing less.

Of course, this is still in a nascent stage, but we can imagine Bug Labs, or another project like it, catering to the whims and fancies of every individual. Want to own a mobile phone that has no keypad (because you hardly ever call people), but has a large screen for videos, a large storage capacity, and none of the Bluetooth, MMS and Smart Phone nonsense? Just build it yourself!



It had 8 or 16 KB of RAM, a two-line display, a single-tasking OS, diary and alarm features (basic reminders), and was even user programmable! Of course, only really advanced users could customise their Organiser IIs, because you had to either use the Organiser Programming Language or machine code to get it to do your bidding. They were tough cookies too, and rumour has it that you could run an Organiser II over with a bus and still be able to extract your data. Ah, they don't make them like that anymore!

Time warp back to today, however, and the reality of it all hits you smack in the face. Today, it's no secret that PDAs are a dying breed! Most people are just getting themselves laptops and enjoying the power of full-fledged computers at their beck and call, rather than buy a PDA that has a special OS, tiny screen, and very often, no QWERTY keyboard! The fact that sizes of tablet PCs are shrinking, and bringing tiny touch-based computers within every senior executive's reach has not helped the PDA cause either. As it stands, the convergence of PDAs and cell phones (what we like to

call Smart Phones), seems to be the only avenue for PDA manufacturers.

Cell Phones

The history of mobile phones is rather muddled. It depends solely on what we could consider to be a "mobile" phone. If it's just wireless voice connectivity between two specified points, then sometime in the 1940s Motorola first popularised its Walkie-Talkie back-pack system. The race for mobile communication technologies was contested by Motorola and Bell labs (AT&T), with Bell engineers proposing the first electronic designs and plans. However, the first mobile phone (wireless, but able to connect to the wired telephone network) was the Motorola DynaTAC (Dynamic Adaptive Total Area Coverage), which Dr Martin Cooper first showed off in 1973. He was also the first person to talk on a cell phone, and his first ever call was to his rival—Joel Engel, then Head of Research, Bell labs. Perhaps you can understand the rivalry better when you picture Dr Cooper standing below a rather tall